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Dave Frishberg

Dave Frishberg was born on March 23, 1933 in St. Paul, Minnesota. He is a highly regarded pianist, vocalist and songwriter, and has performed with an impressive list of jazz luminaries. Dave's distinctive songs have been recorded by Rosemary Clooney, Cleo Laine, Mel Torme and on his own solo recordings.

Dave was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 16, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Clearwater Beach. I'm very pleased to have Dave Frishberg with me—

DF: Thanks, Monk.

MR: who is a songwriter extraordinaire and a man with a unique sense of a lyric, I think.

DF: Well I'm glad to be here.

MR: Can you recall when you look back on your musical career, your first inspiration to write a song?

DF: No, I can't. But I can tell you what impressed me as a child musically. I think the first thing that really made me just excited was Gilbert & Sullivan. I just thought that, especially "The Mikado." My family had those recordings on '78s, with Martin Green and the D'Oyly Carte, you know this was the 1940s. And I really listened hard to Gilbert & Sullivan and as a kid, I mean before I was ten or twelve years old, I could sing practically the whole "Mikado" plus other Gilbert & Sullivan stuff too. And I still find that music just intensely gratifying. And words too.

MR: Oh yeah. And you were in Minnesota?

DF: Yeah.

MR: Grew up?

DF: Yeah.

MR: What was the musical atmosphere like in your town?

DF: Well bebop was being born around that time. When I was growing up, when I was in high school and at the University of Minnesota, I was a member of bebop groups. I mean we called ourselves bebop groups and we tried to imitate the music that we heard on recordings. And the bands around town that were working in the clubs were bebop groups. Now there was another bunch of musicians that I didn't know too well and that was Doc Evans and some other players who were the traditional players. And there was a strong scene going on in the Twin Cities at that time. But I wasn't part of that at all. I was young and looking forward to bebop.

MR: Okay, so you guys were thinking pretty modern then.

DF: We thought we were, yeah. We were. We were cutting edge.

MR: Uh huh. What led you to the piano? Just one in the house?

DF: Yeah. There was a piano in the house and I just went to it naturally. Took some lessons for a while, maybe from age eight to age nine or something like that. But I didn't enjoy the lessons and I hated the discipline of the practice so I abandoned the lessons but kept at the piano, yeah, myself.

MR: I guess you did. When I look at the list of people that you've played with and that have played with you it's pretty darn impressive. You eventually, like a lot of people, moved to New York. Was that specifically for the music?

DF: Yeah it sure was. I had just come out of the Air Force. I had spent two years in the Air Force and I was deciding which coast to go to. I knew I wasn't going home to the Twin Cities. But I was going to go to either New York or California. And I ran into, well I was stationed in Salt Lake. And the Woody Herman band came through. I met some guys on that band and hung out with them for the couple days they were in town. And they encouraged me. And one of them was Bob Newman, a saxophone player. He encouraged me to come to York. He says, "You've got to go to New York, that's where it's really happening, that's where the most creatives are," he says, "that's where Sonny Rollins is." "Oh," I said. Then I understood. Of course I've got to go to New York. Well it turns out I did go to New York. And Bob of course said, "As soon as you get there, look me up, I can get you work right away." Wouldn't you know it, when I got there, a few months later, Bob was nowhere to be found. He had left New York by that time. So that was it. And I stayed in New York for fifteen years or so and played a lot. I mean I didn't lack for work and got to play with just about all the good musicians I ever dreamed of playing with. But I never met or got to play with Sonny Rollins. I saw him in person a couple of times, yeah, but I don't think I ever did have the pleasure of meeting him.

MR: Wow. He's a very unique guy.

DF: Yeah, he was one of my real heroes, and remains that way.

MR: Yeah. He has such a way of interpreting songs and finding the —

DF: Well it's the old Sonny Rollins. I'm talking about the Sonny Rollins of the 1960s maybe that really got to me. The newer stuff I haven't paid much attention to. But the way he handled pop songs, like you said, that really got to me. I loved it. That was a mind at work that I really was interested in there.

MR: Showing up in New York, is it mostly like word of mouth, meeting the right people?

DF: Yeah.

MR: That's how you get into the scene?

DF: Yeah. The first day I was there I went to Junior's Bar. It was on 52nd Street between Broadway and Eighth Avenue. And someone told me, probably Bob Newman, as soon as

you get to New York go to Junior's Bar, that's where everybody is, and just tell them that you're there. I did it. The first night I was there like somebody took me to a jam session. And I played, met a couple of musicians, one of them was a guy I've known ever since, a bass player by the name of Jack Six. And the very first night, it might have been the second night, but I was a new, just completely new to the city, that's when I met Jack. Yeah just hanging out, getting your face in and gaining a reputation in those days at the jam sessions, which were in lofts in New York City. You go to the loft and you play. It wasn't really competitive. It didn't feel competitive to me, although reputations were made in that situation. But it was more a camaraderie and sharing of musical material. And I learned a lot from people, talking to them and playing and hearing them play in these loft sessions.

MR: What kind of tunes would they call at those things?

DF: Well I remember we used to play "I Remember You," that was a hip standard of the time, and "Have You Met Miss Jones," some — I mean the repertoire that I enjoyed playing was the song bag, the American Songbook tunes. I love that. But then of course we were into the originals, like the Sonny Rollins originals, "Pent Up House" and I forget the titles but we all knew them. And standards. You know in those days repertoire was so important, especially to a piano player you know.

MR: I guess.

DF: Well I guess I shouldn't say especially to a piano player. For everyone. Because we were all, you know it was the days when you said yes to everything. And there was no gig too meager or demeaning to say no to. You know? You said yes. And therefore you had a lot of adventures and also learned a lot of stuff. But you needed to be prepared. And repertoire was your arsenal of things that you brought to the table. So when you're looking at the union, you'd be down at the union hall on Wednesday afternoons, you know about the union hall?

MR: Yeah, but I want to hear how this worked.

DF: And then you'd be hanging out there just so you'd get your face known you know. And the musicians would take you by the hand and they'd lead you around and this is Irving Bower or whatever his name is you know, and he's got a board and he's writing down things and he says, "You know all the tunes?" And then you're supposed to say yes, you know. Some people would say no. Some people would say all but one.

MR: Hope they don't call that one.

DF: Yeah. So you had to know songs. And then of course at the sessions you learned repertoire, jazz repertoire. But the idea at the jam sessions was to just blow your brains out. You were there to blow choruses and just play hard, as hard as you could as a jazz player you know. And it was all in private. It was all for the visceral pleasure of the

whole thing. Also it was socially interesting. I met a lot of people there for the first time in lofts.

MR: How did you find out about the jam sessions, just word of mouth? Or were there certain places that they happened all the time?

DF: Oh yeah, there was the loft on 34th Street, there was the loft on Sixth Avenue in the 30s, those were the two main ones I went to. There were others down in the Bowery district. One of the lofts I went to a lot belonged to the famous photographer W. Eugene Smith. Have you ever seen his name around? He's a photographer, a journalist photographer who is now deceased but he was a very prominent *Life* magazine photographer along with like Capra and those others. And this was his loft. And in fact I think he had two floors of that building and living on his level was Hall Overton, a pianist and arranger. And they had a nice piano there. And I used to go there to make a lot of sessions. I met a lot of wonderful musicians there.

MR: So going back to this union thing, they would put bands together for certain occasions?

DF: Well no these were for club dates. These weren't jazz dates.

MR: No I know that. The club dates, and they'd say okay this is an anniversary party or something?

DF: Well we wouldn't know what kind of party it was, it would just be like Sid Zieler's got a job, he's doing a job Friday night and he needs a piano player.

MR: Okay.

DF: And do you know all the tunes? And then you'd say yes, and then okay.

MR: Would they give you like any instruction like what to wear?

DF: Yeah. They'd say wear a tux and be there at eleven o'clock or how do you get there, well someone will pick you up just right outside of Junior's, okay.

MR: Well I'm just trying to figure out, the people that were hiring the musicians, they didn't call the union, right?

DF: Nobody called the union. It was all face to face meeting people and gaining a reputation. The people who wanted to get in the club date business were intent on impressing the contractors and the band leaders. And they cultivated those friendships. They probably sent them gifts, who knows? I don't know. That wasn't my end. But I did my share of that work. Yeah, the union didn't really provide much of an employment agency function at all.

MR: I see, yeah.

DF: It was a place to pick up checks if there were any, and to meet with union officials regarding contracts. In those days a lot of musicians were on payrolls and there were a lot of contracts involved. It's a different music business today. It's not like it used to be. It

was pretty union dominated. If you were a union member there was very, very good worthwhile work that you were eligible to do.

MR: What was your first experience in the recording studio in New York?

DF: It was a kind of pop record that was being produced by a man that I had met and had been working with, an accordion player by the name of Mat Matthews. You know who I'm talking about?

MR: No.

DF: He was from Holland. Played button accordion. Very good player. But in this instance he was the producer and I had been rehearsing with some singers in his studio and so forth. He liked my playing and he put me on this date and I was reading the part. And I remember the band. I mean do you want me to go into who the band was?

MR: Yes.

DF: Because I remember who the band was. It was astonishing. It was — the drummer was Osie Johnson and the bass player was Wendell Marshall. I played piano. A guy by the name of Everett Barksdale played guitar. Clark Terry. Big Nick Nicholas was the tenor player, Jerome Richardson, and somebody else. Okay. I mean it was, wow, what am I doing in the studio with these people? And this was my very first record date. My knees were like knocking. I couldn't believe it, that Mat had called me for this. Wow, this is heavy duty, in New York you know.

MR: Yeah. And all those heavy duty guys in there making —

DF: Oh they were studio players. That was their life. But I knew who every one of them were. So they didn't know me at all so I walk in there and Mat, the song was named "Prisoner of Love" you know. And I don't want to tell you the name of the girl who was singing but it was "Prisoner of Love" with a kind of a rock triplet background to it. And then she would sing, she'd start [sings] A-lone from night to night, [scats]. And the part went, and I'm turning these pages, it went about ten pages. And it was all written out, ding-ding-ding, bung-bung-bung, with slashes, every little triplet was written out. And I just, I mean I just read every one of them. At the end of take one I turned around and the musicians were laughing at me you know. And I said, "What happened, did I do something wrong?" And they says, "We've never seen anybody read that stuff before." But Osie Johnson was very nice and he said, "But you know it felt great," he said, "it sounded great, it felt great." So he put me at ease. But they were laughing. I thought it was my duty to read every one.

MR: A typical kind of six-eight thing?

DF: That's right. Yeah it was.

MR: Well a question I've been interested in is how much the jazz players played a role in creating that kind of pop music of the day.

DF: I don't think they could create — for that day? I don't know that they did at all.

MR: I mean but they were in the studio doing a lot of the work.

DF: Some of them were, some of them were. There were a lot of musicians who worked in the studios that weren't really jazz musicians that were studio musicians and that was their specialty. And they played all different kinds of music and they were very, very versatile and they were the kinds of musicians that the producers and arrangers loved to have around. They were available with instant help with instant answers to things, with instant remedy for whatever you want. You want this beat? Klunk. You know. And they were the professional studio players. They were more than jazz players, they were broader than that.

MR: Okay. They had to be able to do whatever was required at the drop of a hat and know different styles.

DF: They often defined what was required. They were that influential and they were that powerful.

MR: I'm looking at some of the guys you played with — Ben Webster, what was he like to work with?

DF: Well he was pretty scary. I mean he was inspirational to me. I was in the middle of my Duke Ellington period when I got the job so I was really ready for it you know. And it was a wonderful learning experience for me and so much fun musically, I can't tell you. It was a really nourishing musical thing. And we had great rhythm players — Mel Lewis was the drummer and Richard Davis was the bass player. I never had so much fun being in a rhythm section. They were so good. And they just, we just sailed along. It was wonderful. But when I say it was scary, Ben was — we never knew what to expect from Ben. He would explode, his temper would flare unexpectedly and it was scary sometimes, at the Half Note one time he mouthed off to a policeman and the rest of the evening was really upsetting. I mean they backed him up against a wall and they called squad cars and it was just a nightmare. He had this volatile temper.

MR: Someone once said to you, "Jazz is okay but it ain't got no words."

DF: Sergeant Garr in the Air Force, yeah, he said that to me. He's right.

MR: So you remedied that situation?

DF: Well I don't think I write jazz words, you know, I just write words.

MR: Right, okay.

DF: But he's right about jazz, I thought it was an interesting comment. It ain't got no words.

MR: It is a little leap that jazz has to take because it doesn't have that immediate message of what's the song about.

DF: But that was never jazz's message. If jazz had a message I don't think it was talking about what the song was about. It's just talking about look what we could do with this.

MR: Why did you move to Los Angeles?

DF: You mean when I left New York?

MR: Yeah.

DF: Well I was offered a job and I took it. I wanted to get out of New York at the time. My marriage had, we'd split up and we were planning to divorce. And I didn't really want to stay in New York much. And I got a gig offered to me in Los Angeles to write songs, special material on the staff of a television show for NBC, it was going to be contract for 13 weeks of shows, whatever. I took it and never came back. I went out there and took the job and stayed out in California for another fifteen years.

MR: What's the scene, how is it different from New York at that time?

DF: A lot of places to park, that's one thing. A lot of parking places.

MR: This is important. So you had a whole different group of people to work with including Jack Sheldon.

DF: Well I had a lot of friends who already had preceded me to California. The whole Merv Griffin band was out there and I knew all those guys. And other musicians that had moved to California. It was good to be back with them again. But you're right, I met all the west coast gang and that was terrific. I loved that part of my life. I had a great time in L.A. Although I didn't like living in L.A. as a place to live. I thought it was a malignant environment. I hated it. But many adventures and many happy memories.

MR: I see you even did some work with the Tijuana Brass?

DF: I was with Herb Alpert's re-formed, he re-invented the Tijuana Brass ten years after the big hit. It was the middle 70s and he wanted to come back with a more jazz oriented — he wanted like a Chuck Mangione type approach, kind of a picturesque, macho, flashy jazz approach with a lot of rhythm and a lot of Latin. And it was fun. That was a hot band, very good musicians on it including some from the original Tijuana Brass like the drummer, Nick Ceroli and John Pisano the guitar player. It was a hot band. But it never caught on with the public the way the original band did. But we had a ball. We traveled around for a couple of years and it was like being with the New York Yankees, it was first class. It was really fun.

MR: I want to ask you about a few of your tunes if you don't mind. To your knowledge are you the only songwriter who has been commissioned by a baseball team?

DF: I have no idea. And it certainly wasn't in the form of a commission, it was more of a permission.

MR: Really?

DF: Yeah. I mean they asked me if I wouldn't mind writing it. I mean they kind of invited me to write it. And it's "Dodger Blue" you're speaking of. Yeah. But there was no commission involved really. That's too nice a word for it. It was really, they were nice

enough to ask me to write it and they said that if I did write it they'd be happy to play it over the loudspeaker. So we recorded it with a big orchestra arranged and conducted by Alan Broadbent and Sue Rainey was the singer. And it was indeed used on the public address and other uses.

MR: It must have been like a little puzzle trying to put that whole lyric together.

DF: Well I think just about all songs are that way. I've often thought of them as that way. Always it's very much like a crossword puzzle of some kind, yeah.

MR: And I think I've read that you said the title is half the battle sometimes.

DF: Well the title is the springboard that I work off of, absolutely. I always try to find a title. If there's a melody given me I always try to find a title in it, the first thing. Now where is the title going to be? What part of the melody will bear that weight? And then when you find a title that often given an idea as to what the attitude of the song might be, depending on the title, and it gives you an idea of who might be singing it or what the point of view might be. It also gives you an idea of how to pay the lyric off. It's nice and neat to find a title that will pay itself off in some way, that will fulfill itself by the end of the song. And in those ways finding a title is very helpful, especially in beginning a song, giving you a start.

MR: That inspiration, do you find yourself looking at current events or just social things?

DF: No I don't. I don't. I've had, as a professional songwriter I've been asked and commissioned, hired, to write topical songs sometimes. So some of the songs I've written are indeed topical. But I don't enjoy writing them because they fall into a domain that I'm not that much interested in, it's material, as opposed to songs. It's material. And I had to write a lot of topical things when I worked for that television show. It's demanding work and well it was demanding because it was television.

MR: Can you give me an example?

DF: Well the stuff that I wrote for that show?

MR: Yeah.

DF: The show was called "The Funny Side" on NBC. Gene Kelly was the host. A weekly comedy show. And my job was to write a production number each week. It had to last nearly five minutes and it had to involve up to twelve cast members. And the more cast members were involved, the better they liked it. So it was really strange songwriting. It was writing for groups of people, for two people here who would answer what two people over there did, and they would react lyrically according to some plot. Each week the song had to be about the week's topic. So I had to write songs about the funny side of blah-blah, the funny side of blah-blah. The funny side of money. The funny side of news. The funny side of television. You know, the funny side of advertising. So I had to write songs that were like funny, it was comedy. It was comedy writing.

MR: Did it ever irk you that you were writing things that probably were going to be used once? Or was it just the job?

DF: One of the songs, called "The Sports Page," I used later on in life, but it was the only one of the songs of the bunch that I wrote that had any application later. Yes, it was, there was something uncomfortable about knowing that you were writing something that was deliberately ephemeral. It was going to be gone. And in those days there wasn't even routine taping of a show. It was done once.

MR: It's not going to go into syndication.

DF: I'd love to — I do have recordings that I made myself from when I was there, I've listened on television at home to the show and I put a microphone up next to the speaker of the TV and recorded it onto my Tandberg you know. But that's how long ago it was.

MR: Right. That's really interesting. Oh and I see a little later on you also did some stuff for "Schoolhouse Rock," which was a great show.

DF: That was Bob Dorough's baby. Somebody thought the idea up but Dorough contributed the musical thing. He was the musical director and it was the stamp of Bob Dorough that made that show what it was. That and the great artwork. Dorough is a particular hero of mine.

MR: Yeah, you guys have collaborated a number of times.

DF: We haven't collaborated that much but we've known each other for 40 years now and I've been involved in a lot of Bob's projects. Let's put it that way. Collaboration was "I'm Hip" that we did together, that was our song that we wrote jointly. And recently we have a two piano show that we've been doing. And we recorded it in front of an audience in L.A. and it's on Blue Note. The show is called "Who's on First." And that's the name of the CD.

MR: All right. Do you have particular comedians that you like?

DF: Comedians?

MR: Comedians, yeah.

DF: Oh, Albert Brooks, yeah I really like him. Oh I can't think of anyone else right off the top of my head. But I know I admire him. Oh, and I like Christopher Guest and Harry Shearer, the guys that did "Spinal Tap," and I also like the people who did "Best of Show," the dog movie that's current. I don't know if you've seen that yet.

MR: I have not seen that yet. It sounds like a good subject.

DF: Yeah Christopher Guest is one of my heroes I guess.

MR: I don't know how to ask this question, but do you — I'll just ask it — do you think your lyrics are funny?

DF: Sometimes, yeah.

MR: Sometimes?

DF: Sometimes.

MR: I mean sometimes it's hard to be objective about your own work.

DF: Well I mean for them to be. I mean for them to be but I mean a lot of times they're not jokes, and I don't know if they're meant to draw laughs, but they're certainly meant to amuse the listener, yeah, right.

MR: I have a couple of little pieces of material that I wanted to—

[audio interlude]

MR: I'm afraid I don't know what that means.

DF: It doesn't mean anything.

MR: Doesn't mean anything?

DF: Well yeah, it means to flirt outrageously with somebody. One of my wives, an ex-wife of mine made that up — that expression up.

MR: No kidding.

DF: And I thought it was very colorful. I have no idea what cakes she's talking about. But it's interesting, it's a good turn of phrase.

MR: Isn't it. I like it. It's interesting where inspiration comes from sometimes. This is one of my favorite things that is somewhat borrowing I guess.

[audio interlude]

MR: Can you still hit those notes? I really love what you did with "Walk on, Walk on with Hope in Your Heart."

DF: Yeah a lot of people laugh, I love it when they laugh at that. I think it's funny too.

MR: Yeah. It's unexpected I think and it really is a clever song too with all the kind of cliches of the language that we hear so often. How long does it take you on average to write a lyric like that?

DF: Like "Blizzard of Lies?"

MR: "Blizzard of Lies," yeah.

DF: That one took years. Not because it took years, because I carried the title around in my head for years before I ever acted on it. But I remember thinking that would be a great title. And then I never really followed through on it. I had it in mind for a decade though. But otherwise it depends. If I'm under the gun, and believe it or not there are situations even in today's music business where I might be under the gun, like Johnny Mandel called me about a month ago before I came on this trip that I'm on now, and told me that he needed some material for a new record he was producing that was liable to be a popular record, and he told me he wanted me to write lyrics to his old song "Hershey Bar," that Stan Getz record from 1948 or whatever. And he wanted it pretty quickly and promptly. So I rose to the occasion. I can still do it.

MR: Excellent.

DF: Although it's tough for me to start, I'm a procrastinator. And I waited again until the last minute, but I got it in there. It took me three days, four days. But what it is is three days of nothing. And the fourth day of pouring forth. Without the three days of nothing, the fourth day was not going to happen. And that's a horrible routine to have to get used to. I mean you might be a writer yourself, and you know how it feels to have nothing. But you've got to go through the nothing, trying again and again and again before the something will happen. That's the hard part.

MR: All the time you are saying yeah, yeah, it's going to come, it's going to come.

DF: Exactly.

MR: You just wonder like—

DF: And the thing is, don't stop, it's okay. Yeah this does feel doomed but it's not. Keep going you keep telling yourself.

MR: That can be a little nerve wracking, especially if you have people waiting on you I suppose, or counting on you.

DF: Well it can be nerve wracking and it can also be stimulating and it can be an impetus to your writing. It can make you write.

MR: I think I have this—

[audio interlude]

MR: I love this, it's got a certain Americana.

DF: Glen Campbellesque, yeah I know. I was trying to write that way. I was trying to write like — I don't know what you call it, we call it country & western or whatever. This was the middle 60s and you know I was starting to write songs and I figured I might as well try to write for the market. And this was the market part of it. The publisher actually said to me, "I like these, these are nice songs and everything and they're very funny and very nice, but you know, why don't you go home and write some country-western stuff. Write a cowboy song."

MR: Really?

DF: "Write some cowboy songs, I can get you some records." So I went home and I wrote some. This is not the only one, I wrote maybe a half a dozen of them. But I like this one.

MR: Yeah, I love this song. This chord change — same thing that's in "Georgia," isn't it? Like the one to the major three or something?

DF: Well it's the three chord, yeah.

MR: It's got a character to it.

DF: It's very churchy and it sounds like Bach harmony. I mean yeah, it's Theory I is what it is.

MR: It's Theory I.

DF: That's it.

MR: Well, good work. Who are your — do you have piano heroes?

DF: Yeah I do. The first thing that comes into my mind is Jimmy Rowles. I've always been crazy about his playing, ever since I heard the records he made in the 1940s, I was crazy about his playing. And when I finally met him years later, he didn't disappoint me. He was just — he'd even become a greater piano player than I even knew about. He was my favorite. Mel Powell knocked me out. I loved the way he articulated his music. It was beautiful. Teddy Wilson still thrills me, just the exuberance of his playing when he was playing in the 1930s on the Billie Holiday records and some of the Benny Goodman small band sextet records. Teddy Wilson is just on fire. I loved his playing. Nat Cole just killed me. Tatum did too but in a different way. Tatum seemed unattainable. There was no way to try to match that. No way to try to play that game. Although a lot of piano players can do it, but not me, I couldn't play that game. Jeez, that's a tough game.

MR: I know. When you listen to that you just say that's not possible. How could you think that fast and then play that fast.

DF: Yeah. And yet I'll tell you, I think the greatest technical piano player I ever heard in my life was Errol Garner. I think he took the prize. I never heard anybody so virtuosic as what he did, and that includes Tatum as far as I'm concerned. Garner got the greatest sound out of a piano, and generated the most power and swing and lyricism out of a piano of anybody I can think of. He's quite a remarkable player I think. Not real influential, because he's pretty non-copyable, Errol Garner.

MR: That's a heck of a statement right there I think. Let me think about that for a moment. He wasn't an influence because — not as much perhaps — because people could not take from his style and continue it?

DF: I think he just opened a lot of piano players' ears to color and rhythmic punches that they hadn't thought of. I mean he really was such a unique player that he contributed a lot, this is what I'm saying. I think he's overlooked as a great contributor. I don't even think he was mentioned in the Ken Burns thing at all, Errol Garner. Anyway I always loved his playing. Al Haig, Bud Powell, Hank Jones, Tommy Flanagan.

MR: Do you get much time to woodshed at the piano these days?

DF: Well yeah I do. I don't exactly woodshed. I don't know, I go into spasms of, like for a few weeks or a few months I get interested in learning repertoire or making up a repertoire for myself. You know what spurs me to practice is if somebody wants me to make an album and I've got to come up with piano solos, like I did for this last Arbors album. I had to kind of get some stuff in shape. That spurs me to play. I do quite a bit of sideman playing, not quite a bit, but a couple times a week maybe I play in Portland.

MR: I liked your interpretation of "Groovin' High" on this CD.

DF: Oh thank you. Yeah. I like that too.

MR: Yeah. It's an interesting way to treat it. Someone suggested I ask you about your recent trip to Miami, and something about directions.

DF: Oh, I got lost in Miami. It's not that interesting a story, I mean it's just a tough town to drive in. And it's a very scary town to get lost in. And you are forewarned not to get lost in Miami. People would say to me, "Now if you get lost don't stop on the street and ask anybody for directions." And I said, "Well what do I do?" "Come back here and start from the beginning again and we'll tell you how to do it." Scary. And I did get lost maybe eight or nine times. It's not that funny a story.

MR: Yeah. I'll have to remember that if I'm down there. What's on the bill for you coming up? Obviously you're down here playing these festivals. Do you like doing these jazz parties?

DF: The fun of it for me — you know there's not much playing to do. It's mostly waiting around to play. And so from that point of view they are kind of frustrating. You leave four days or three days later not having hardly played more than forty minutes. There's ten piano players here, and only one of us can appear at a time so I played twenty minutes today, wait all day and play twenty minutes tomorrow night, wait another day and play forty minutes. That's the downside. The upside is I get to see people that I haven't seen in years and you can see how I love to talk, this — I love to be able to tell stories and talk and get into stuff, and that's what happens here. Because people like Kenny Davern for instance, who I've known for forty years, we talk about the same things all the time, but we still like to do it. So I see a lot of old people — old people is right — old cronies. And then I meet younger people that I'd never get a chance to meet, like I met Al Cohn's son here, Joe Cohn, he was about the best guitar player I ever heard in my life, and meeting him was a pleasure. I never would have met him. Because the work I do now is all by myself. I just do a solo act. So this is a social oasis for me you know, and I like it for that.

MR: It is great fun to just like hang out in the lobby and watch.

DF: It's a little like a class reunion, it really is.

MR: You've got new songs in the can for —

DF: I have some that I haven't recorded yet. And I have some brand new ones, yeah. So I wouldn't call them in the can.

MR: They're in—

DF: No they're in the trunk or whatever you call it, the repository of songs. Yeah there are some ready to be used.

MR: What's it like to place songs these days, or do you have a reputation enough that—

DF: Well I'm getting a reputation now that singers look for my work because they pick up on new songs really quickly. My song "Sideman" was covered almost immediately by two female singers, which I thought was kind of odd but gratifying. But most of the songs I

use myself, I just sing them, record them, and then I do my act and that's my ammunition you know. I mean I'm writing them now mainly for myself to sing, which is fine.

MR: That's good.

DF: Yeah. But number one it means they may not be covered a lot, and number two it means too that they're going to be of a certain character which doesn't require a great voice. And that dimension shapes my song to a certain degree. There's not many of them that are ariose or that display the voice. So placing songs with singers is often — it has to do with giving the singer something that he or she will be able to sing. That's what singers want. A lot of singers, that's why they're singers, right?

MR: Right. Because they've got the instrument.

DF: But when I write I'm writing according to the limitations of my own vocal ability. The song is not going to be that, they're not going to display great singing, nor are they going to rely on long and loud held notes. You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah.

DF: Well that to some degree, to a big degree, shapes my songs. I bet Mose Allison would say the same thing. A lot of his songs are shaped by the way he sings.

MR: Absolutely.

DF: Dorough on the other hand is a different kind of composer. He's not bound by his own limitations. Dorough writes for a voice, and he's a more thorough composer, a more versatile composer than I am. He writes a lot of songs that singers get their teeth into. "Love Came on Stealthy Fingers" and songs like that are ballads in demand by singers, and they use it to show off their voice. Carmen McRae and people like that, they bend it around. I don't have a lot of songs like that.

MR: Yeah. If you look back in your career — this is kind of a hard question — but are any gigs or certain times that stand out as really memorable, either negative or positive or humorous reasons?

DF: Oh Jeez, well Monk, I mean there's so—

MR: I know there's so many.

DF: It's one gig after another, I mean what do you want? Each one of them, they all had their own stories. I guess the gig I think of the most as my golden age of New York playing was the one at the Half Note, which I held, along with other piano players, Ross Tompkins and Roger Kellaway and I maybe, were the three players that were used as house players. We were the utility guys. So we got to play with a lot of great players. And my specialty was with Al Cohn and Zoot Sims. That was the band I felt at home with. I spent eight years with them.

MR: They were a great match, weren't they?

DF: Yeah. Oh yeah. And then in L.A., oh I don't know I guess the most fun I had was the Herb Alpert days. In Portland I think my favorite gig was with Becky Kilgore, the singer, the Portland singer who I met up there and we had a job together in a hotel two nights a week for five years. And just a duo. And I loved that gig. And last week I finished three weeks at the Algonquin in New York in what I described to myself as the favorite gig of my life it was so much fun. So that was — I just finished a memorable gig.

MR: Who was on that gig, was it just you?

DF: It was just me at the Algonquin, yeah.

MR: Nice room, huh?

DF: Yeah it was great, it was great.

MR: Do you ever do any teaching?

DF: No.

MR: Is it possible in your head, to describe what's in your head when you are improvising?

DF: Yes it is impossible. It's impossible, yeah. I have no idea. Improvising is not such a big deal as people make it. And you are a musician and you know what I'm saying. Every musician can improvise. Anybody can improvise. And it's no big deal. So I'm not impressed by that. And I think the importance of improvisation is over exaggerated.

MR: Well what is a big deal then?

DF: Well I mean the quality of what you're playing is the big deal. I mean you can't just say that you improvise and you're going to sound like Zoot Sims 'cause you're not. And then what are you going to say when Johnny Hodges plays the same thing, exactly the same way for thirty years. He's not improvising, but are you going to say it's anything less than the most beautiful thing you've ever heard? So improvising is not really where it's at. Jazz to me is an attitude about music, it's a certain sensibility brought to the performance of certain music that's designed or that's friendly to jazz treatment. Pop songs, ideally, I think that's what fed the jazz ethic, was the pop songs.

MR: Of the 30s?

DF: Of the 20s, 30s, 40s, the golden, I mean Jerome Kern, Sigmund Romberg, Victor Herbert, Jerome Kern, Irving Berlin, Richard Rodgers, George Gershwin, that's what changed jazz. That's what opened the jazz musicians' ears. That's how jazz evolved. It was never referred to once in Ken Burns' documentary by the way. Not once was that ever mentioned. The food of us jazz players, all of the jazz players, was the work of the greatest pop songwriters we've ever known and thank God we all, everybody coincided in the 1920s or 1930s. It was a lot deeper and a lot more musically oriented than Ken Burns' thing would suggest. The Ken Burns thing was heavy on the sociology, light on the musicology. The minor seventh chord had more to do with jazz sounding the way it does than the blues does. But the minor seventh chord is not that easy to describe or make

dramatic. You know what I mean? Where would Charlie Parker be if it weren't for "All the Things You Are" and Jerome Kern, who defined the chordal movement of bebop with that song. That whole song is about bebop and where bebop went. The way he manipulated harmonies and then melody, and the way he harmonized that whole thing opened up jazz musicians' ears all over the place, including a genius or two like Charlie Parker or Lester Young. The minor seventh is what changed jazz, okay?

MR: Because of where it led?

DF: Exactly. Because of where it led the ear. And the minor seventh was a device of the pop song composers. It was a device of Ravel I suppose, but I'm talking about the pop songwriters like even the unschooled ones were using the minor seventh like Irving Berlin. The trained ones like Kern were using it too as part of their arsenal. It was the two chord, the minor seventh. That's what changed jazz. That's why jazz grew up the way it did. That's my feeling.

MR: I like the theory.

DF: Yeah.

MR: And it allowed, did it allow for those songs for instance that don't start on the one chord.

DF: Yeah.

MR: Is that part of what you're talking about?

DF: No I'm just talking about how music was harmonized.

MR: Yeah, okay.

DF: The decline of the dominant seventh and its replacement by suspended introductory harmony.

MR: All right.

DF: You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah.

DF: That's what changed jazz.

MR: Wow.

DF: A lot more than race or some kind of purposeful artistic mission. I mean it was the opening up of the American ear by Gershwin, Cole Porter, that's it. I mean that's it. That's the way I feel.

MR: Okay. Great statement. It's going to give me some food for thought for sure. Yeah there's an awful lot of statements made about what jazz players were intending to do and their role in society and all that, and maybe it's not that complicated.

DF: It's like joining a lodge, a secret handshake, everybody knows it's like a two chord.

MR: I feel like I just got a little secret of life here.

DF: Yeah, yeah. Good luck.

MR: Good luck. Okay. I won't quit my day gig on that though. Well I know you have to go perform.

DF: I'm happy to go. I mean not that I haven't enjoyed this, but let's play already.

MR: Right let's do something, right?

DF: Right, exactly.

MR: I appreciate your time, it's been really a fascinating conversation.

DF: I enjoyed it.

MR: And I'll be listening later on tonight.